matters popes may err, in their institutional role they are infallible.[99] For example, Pope Alexander VI erred in breaking his vow of celibacy, having a mistress and siring several children, yet when defining official church teachings on matters of ethics or theology, he was incapable of mistake.

In line with these views, the Catholic Church has always employed a self-correcting mechanism to supervise its human members in their personal affairs, but it never developed a mechanism for amending the Bible or for amending its 'deposit of faith'. This attitude is manifest in the few formal apologies the Catholic Church issued for its past conduct. In recent decades, several popes apologised for the mistreatment of Jews, women, non-Catholic Christians and indigenous cultures, as well as for more specific events such as the sacking of Constantinople in 1204 and the abuse of children in Catholic schools. It is commendable that the Catholic Church made such apologies at all; religious institutions rarely do so. Nevertheless, in all these cases, the popes were careful to shift responsibility away from scriptures and from the church as an institution. Instead, the blame was laid on the shoulders of individual churchmen who misinterpreted scriptures and deviated from the true teachings of the church.

For example, in March 2000, Pope John Paul II conducted a special ceremony in which he asked forgiveness for a long list of historical crimes against Jews, heretics, women and indigenous people. He apologised 'for the use of violence that some have committed in the service of truth'. This terminology implied that the violence was the fault of 'some' misguided individuals who didn't understand the truth taught by the church. The pope didn't accept the possibility that perhaps these individuals understood exactly what the church was teaching and that these teachings just were not the truth.[100]

Similarly, when Pope Francis apologised in 2022 for the abuses against indigenous people in Canada's church-run residential schools, he said, 'I ask for forgiveness, in particular, for the ways in which many members of the church … cooperated … in projects of cultural destruction and forced assimilation.'[101] Note his careful shifting of responsibility. The fault lay with 'many members of the church', not with the church and its teachings. As if it were never official church doctrine to destroy indigenous cultures and forcefully convert people.

In fact, it wasn't a few wayward priests who launched the Crusades, imposed laws that discriminated against Jews and women or orchestrated